

Beaver, Lawrence counties get \$1 million in EPA brownfield grants

By J.D. Prose Calkins Media | Posted: Thursday, May 29, 2014 4:00 am

Beaver County will receive \$600,000 and Lawrence County is in line for \$400,000 in grants under the Environmental Protection Agency's brownfields assessment program to reclaim former industrial sites and encourage redevelopment, the agency announced Wednesday.

In Beaver County, \$400,000 will be used to fund up to 22 environmental site assessments on properties potentially contaminated with hazardous waste, while \$200,000 in grants will fund up to 10 assessments for sites thought to have petroleum contamination.

"Both types of funding will be used to support community engagement activities and cleanup planning," the EPA said on its website.

Those grants are part of a two-county effort dubbed the Ohio River Brownfields Coalition, which included Beaver County, Aliquippa, Midland, Monaca and Moon Township.

"Our Ohio River coalition is ready to move forward on revitalization and innovation, and we commend U.S. EPA for its continued partnership with Beaver County and its communities," Beaver County Commissioner Dennis Nichols said in a statement.

"The Beaver and Allegheny County region along the Ohio River have been through major struggles with the decline of the steel industry, the loss of tens of thousands of jobs, and major environmental contamination challenges," the county's statement read, "but Beaver County and its partners are poised to continue their progress to transform these brownfields into a vibrant corridor of new advanced manufacturing, mixed-used sustainable development, a key segment of the Ohio River Trail, and new community park and recreational areas."

Nichols said the potential sites do not include the Potter Township property that formerly housed the Horsehead Corp. zinc plant, where Shell Oil Co. is considering building a \$2.5 billion ethane cracker plant.

Lawrence County's funding will be used to assess sites with possible petroleum and hazardous-waste contamination. "The funds will be used for reviewing the list of proposed sites targeted for the next level of environmental site assessment," according to the EPA.

The EPA said the local grants are part of \$67 million in nationwide brownfield funding that will support 264 grants for 171 communities in 44 states.